

tive or a disincentive that you can give, everything is fixed. So, you have to really go out of your way to determine what other than monetary incentive you can hand out, what are the right buttons [to push] in order to motivate and inspire people. In the private sector, the simple solution is to throw more money at the problem. Now, that is not always fruitful as you are not really ensuring that the person is developing in the right way. However, the private sector does try to compensate for it by creating what they call a business partner from the HR side of it to look at what your development plan looks like; and how they can sort of dovetail it into the organisation's plan, which is, I think, a great thing, which in the public sector we don't have—mainly because the public sector is so huge that to have a look at individual plans at every step would need a whole army of people, which probably we can't afford. But there are good practices in the public sector and there are good practices in the private sector.

For instance, in the public sector, I used to always think that people are so promotion-crazy because they don't have any other compensation other than their career track. Well, let me tell you that in the private sector, people are equally promotion-crazy no matter what compensation they get. So, the fact is, people at the end of the day are very similar, and yet the surroundings can be very dissimilar, and therefore our responses... are very dissimilar. And you know, this idea that the public sector doesn't work, I don't know where it stems from; because I was up till one in the night every night for the four years that I was chairman. However, at Salesforce, for instance, there is much more emphasis on work-life balance. I can log any day off in a week, I can make it a four-day week if I need a wellness break, and it is never questioned. In fact, it is celebrated if you take a wellness break, as you're trying to ensure that there is no burnout, because here too, the days are long. Being an MNC, my day starts at India timing of 9:30 am and ends by about 6:00 pm and then San Francisco, which is headquarters, wakes up at 8:30 pm India time. So from 8:30 to 11:30 at night, I have calls planned. There is very little space in between, and sometimes you do need that one day off, just in order to feel that you are all there or get some of your very personal things done.

ON CHOOSING BANKING AS A CAREER

The banking exam was a very general kind—a paper on logic and on general knowledge and English.. I thought I could crack it... So I applied and got selected.

ON BEING THE SBI 'CHAIRMAN'

The statute that created SBI does not have the designation of chairperson... They [the legal team] said go for a change of the Act [to become Chairperson]... I had larger battles to fight.

ON PICKING SALESFORCE AS HER NEXT STINT

The offer [gave me] a chance to have multiple careers.... [and I thought] that it could be an organisation that would give me a lot of added value.

ON HER HUSBAND

Both of us accepted that we had our own space. Many times he didn't accompany me, and I didn't accompany him, but we sort of worked it out.

Q: You're right in pointing out that there is a myth that the public sector does not work and I'll tell you where the myth comes from—instances of where the private sector has been allowed to enter the terrain of the public sector, and the public sector has crumbled or lost enormous market share to the private entrants. For example, BSNL and MTNL losing out to Bharti, or how Air India crumbled when Jet Airways and later IndiGo took over... And this is probably where this myth comes from that the private sector is more competent and more efficient than the public sector.

A: You know, the reason for all this is really not the people themselves, but the enablements that they had. In the public sector, we are totally bound to processes and unless the process is complete in every respect, you are not allowed to proceed. You spoke about telecom; now telecom has undergone huge changes, right? You have to be very nimble and agile on your feet to acquire the latest technology, which the private sector could do much more easily than the public sector. Because, in the public sector, you are under the scrutiny of a lot of people as to how you're spending your funds because you have been funded from taxpayers' money. But at the end of the day, what this ends up doing is make you non-agile, and that is the reason I believe that if the public sector is enabled in the same way as the private sector... things will become much, much better. You know, when I was with SBI, I used to look at the recruitment piece. And I would agonise over it because to select 1,800 probationary officers, I had to go through 180,000 applicants, in a space of nine months. In the private sector, for instance, you don't have to do any of that. You can make the recruitment tomorrow if you want to. However, even there, I have found because you don't want to make a mistake in the people you are taking, often you end up taking the same nine months. So it is possible to find your way out and become far more swift on your feet even within the public sector. And, during my time, the amount of digital initiatives we took up in the bank and where we landed up, I think we were even ahead of the private sector. It can